

IT CORRIDOR

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THE DRY WASTE COLLECTION DRIVE NEAR YOU

Meet three Chennai residents who have brought the healthy practice of squirrelling away dry discards for the recycler to their neighbourhood and also made it regular. These initiatives are having a buy-in from their neighbours **P3**



EARTHEN RESOLVE

In Chennai, an enterprise focussed on making curd pots has completed its golden jubilee due to a man who would not give up. This enterprise is as small as it gets; it has two members on its rolls, he and his wife **P5**

An eternity spent on the home stretch in Kotturpuram

Residents of streets off Gandhi Mandapam Road question the move to close most of the openings in the median and leave some only partially open



An opening in the median on Gandhi Mandapam Road that has been barricaded.

PRINCE FREDERICK

The traffic situation has taken a turn for the worse for residents of streets off Gandhi Mandapam Road in Kotturpuram ever since Greater Chennai Traffic Police reengineered the traffic flow on that busy road.

The issue pertains to "turns" from one side of Gandhi Mandapam Road to

the other, some median openings having been disabled at some points for motorists, and some others reduced to something of a peephole.

That is the dominant sentiment in those parts and it has spilled over into residents' associations' WhatsApp chats in Kotturpuram, a fresh rant landing in a WhatsApp group every time a resident walks in home exhausted from a double-eter-

nity spent at the wheel on the home run.

Chandra Prabhakar, a committee member of Nawab Gardens Residents Welfare Association describes a typical facet of what these residents define as ordeal. She notes that the problem in the Kotturpuram area, on Gandhi Mandapam Main Road, is that most of the openings in the median have been closed and many of the traffic signals have effective-

ly been switched off. As a result, one cannot simply take a right turn or a U-turn where they need to.

She illustrates the issue: "if you are coming from the Nandanam side over the bridge, you have to go all the way beyond Anna University before you are able to take a U-turn."

What is worse than a closed opening in the median is one that is half-closed.

"Temporary metal barricades have been placed, partially blocking the openings. They leave only a small gap, and it is difficult to understand the purpose of leaving such a narrow space because even large cars strug-

gle to take a U-turn there," she continues. "One such opening is opposite Vellayan Street."

Chandra understands that this situation is not unique to Gandhi Mandapam Road, not even to Chennai, and is noticeable across Tamil Nadu, and she is particularly articulating this idea based on a similar traffic experience she had at Avinashi Road in Coimbatore.

"The philosophy behind this may be that if relatively few vehicles need to turn right or make a U-turn, removing those signal-phases allows traffic to flow more smoothly. This system is followed in many foreign countries. However, the problem

is that in our cities, the number of cars, two-wheelers, autos and buses wanting to make right turns and U-turns is extremely high. Instead of distributing these turning movements across multiple junctions, they are concentrated at a few U-turn locations, where vehicles have to compete with fast-moving traffic coming from the opposite direction. Traffic therefore gets bunched up at these locations," she observes.

Zooming in on Gandhi Mandapam Road, this is what Chandra and most other residents of Kotturpuram want: more openings in the median to be left open, not partially but fully.

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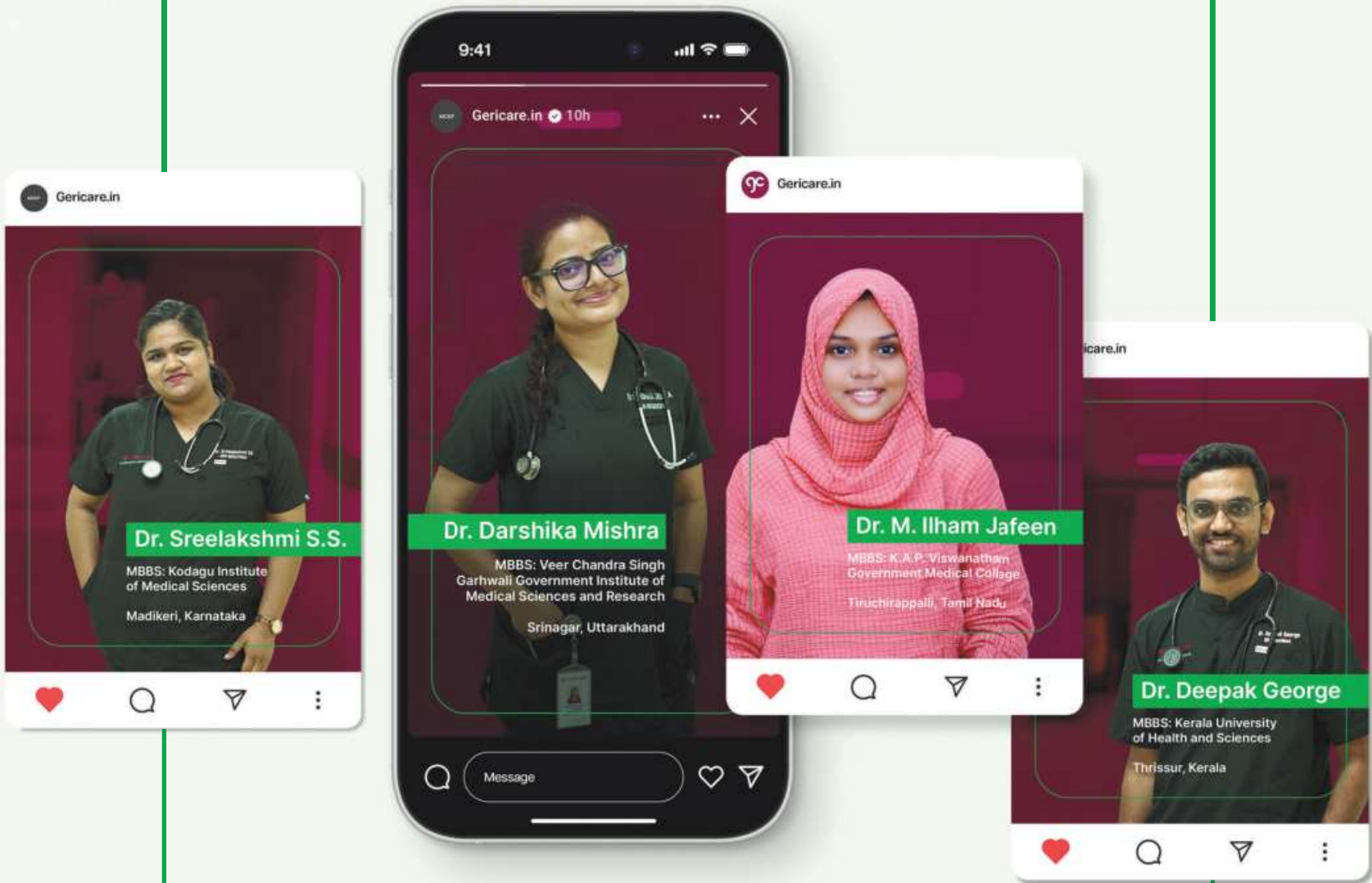
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The *dry waste* collection drive near you



Ashwini H. Pandit at her driveway at Vasudeva Nagar in Thiruvannmiyur

Meet three Chennai residents who have brought the healthy practice of squirrelling away dry discards for the recycler to their neighbourhood and also made it regular. These initiatives are having a buy-in from their neighbours

The initiative, coordinated through the apartment's WhatsApp groups, has also nudged residents towards more mindful disposal practices. Instead of throwing away batteries, keyboards or tube lights, many now message Sreevidhya to ask where they can be responsibly discarded. To Sreevidhya, that change in behaviour is more significant than the volume of waste collected. She believes the foundation for sustainable living must be laid early. "Children should be educated, not just at school, but at home too so they know what can be recycled and why it should never end up as mixed waste," she says.

For details, email sreevidhyaashok03@gmail.com

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A drive in the driveway

Ashwini H. Pandit's driveway at Vasudeva Nagar in Thiruvannmiyur makes room for unlikely occupants, one Saturday every month: washed milk covers, biscuit wrappers, Tetra Paks, cartons, old clothes and discarded electronics items. They are deposited in the space by neighbours, around 15 of them, who share Ashwini's faith in recycling dry waste.

For a year and half now, Ashwini runs this citizens-led dry waste collection drive. "Garbage all over the city and dirty roads triggered me," she says. "I feel anything can be used. It has a life and should not go into the bin."

The collected waste is passed on to organisations that further segregate it before sending it to recyclers.

For Ashwini, the issue is less about the absence of collection systems and more about everyday habits. "Segregation is the key," she notes. "If everything is mixed, nobody would be willing to do it." She hopes more households will begin with small changes like washing and drying recyclable waste, composting kitchen scraps and carrying reusable bags. "We are not even one percent there yet. We have a

long way to go," says Ashwini.

Residents in and around Thiruvannmiyur can drop off their segregated dry waste at Ashwini's monthly collection drive. For details, call 96633 40341

The power of local engagement

Sreevidhya Ashok, a resident of Vijayanagar in Velachery learnt the ropes of community waste man-

agement with Residents of Kasturbanagar Association (ROKA) volunteering with it for six years, being particularly engaged with its city-wide collection drives. And one day, she decided it was essential to bring the initiative closer, make dry waste collection a monthly, local exercise.

Since last month, Sreevidhya has been hosting a collection every

last Saturday. "People were eagerly waiting for the yearly drive, but they found it difficult to store recyclables for so long," she said. "So we thought, why not conduct it every month?"

The response to the first drive validated the move: nearly 300 kg of material was collected, with reusable items accounting for nearly 70% of the collection.

Other efforts

*At Raja Street, Mandaveli, a fortnightly dry waste collection drive is conducted in collaboration with Kabadiwalla Connect; it takes place on a Saturday. For details about nearby drop-off points, call 99400 56069

*Founder of Zero Waste Initiatives at Boutique Bougainvillea in Velachery, Sherin Joseph conducts a monthly waste collection drive every fourth Sunday (2 to 5 p.m.) since January 2025. For details, call 98410 75367

* At RK Nagara in Mandaveli, a community-led waste collection initiative has been running for the past 7-8 years, organised in collaboration with recycling partners. It is held once every 4-5 months. For details, call 70108 48668

* Citizen-led waste management initiatives in MRC Nagar have been active since 2013, dry waste collection drives are conducted once or twice a year, with designated building-level collection points like gyms and common rooms used for drop-offs. For details, call 96000 47586



The shed at Valmiki Nagar to collect dry waste

* A shed installed in Valmiki Nagar nearly seven years ago has been repurposed as a community drop-off point since the first waste collection drive was organised in August 2021. For the past two years, collection drives have been held once every three months, from 11 a.m. to 5 p.m. For details, call 98402 04192

Make it hyperlocal if you can

G. Saranya is guided by a simple but effective principle: waste should not have to travel farther than the people willing to recycle it. And this belief has led her to facilitate a dry waste collection drive within her sprawling residential community in Pallikaranai.

Having regularly dropped off old clothes, footwear and other household discards at citizen-led collection drives while accompanying her mother for medical appointments, Saranya realised that her own community lacked the avenue for responsible disposal of items such as worn-out school uniforms, tattered clothes, toys and footwear.

Rather than spearheading the initiative herself, Saranya chose to play the role of a facilitator. Recognising the scale of her community, home to more than 2,000 families, she reached out to residents' association members and introduced them to organisers already conducting collection drives across Chennai.

The proposal is now taking shape, with discussions under way to organise a dedicated collection drive within the community. Saranya hopes it will evolve into a regular, neighbourhood-level effort, making responsible disposal as convenient as taking out the household waste. "People do not have time to go somewhere and drop these things. If it is a monthly drive, they will start collecting everything," she says



A bus taking a right turn to enter Mahatma Gandhi Road from Lattice Bridge Road, and (below) vehicles from Mahatma Gandhi Road entering First Main Road in Shastri Nagar.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT.

Traffic diversion in Shastri Nagar for metro rail work

The new traffic arrangement will be in place for six months

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

To facilitate metro rail work in the Adyar region, a section of Lattice Bridge Road has been closed to vehicular traffic since last week.

The section lies between the Indira Nagar - Shastri Nagar (Adyar depot) and the Indian Oil petrol bunk junctions near Adyar Telephone Exchange.

Traffic diversion

Motorists from regions along East Coast Road and the IT Corridor



heading towards Adyar beyond the section have to take a right turn at the Adyar depot junction, turn on to Mahatma Gandhi Road, access First Main Road and First Avenue in Shastri Nagar, and then enter Lattice Bridge Road in Adyar.

Motorists from Mahatma Gandhi Road to enter Indira Nagar Second Avenue should turn left at Mahatma Gandhi Road and Lattice Bridge Road, proceed on Lattice Bridge Road, take a U-turn to enter the Bridge Road eastern lane, and along the junction, take a left turn to enter Indira Nagar Second Avenue.

The Adyar bus depot bus stop on Lattice Bridge Road (for buses plying towards Sardar Patel Road and Durgabhai Deshmukh Road) has been relocated to Mahatma Gandhi Road.

This bus stop is where bus route numbers 5E, 47A, and 23C once halted on Mahatma Gandhi Road, after the Adyar Telephone Exchange bus stop on LB Road.

Motorists from Thiruvannmiyur as also the regions along the IT Corridor who want to reach Besant Nagar should enter Mahatma Gandhi Road, turn left to enter First Main Road and right to Eighth Cross Street, then proceed on Eighth Cross Street, 10th Cross Street, and Mahatma Gandhi Road.

Motorists on Mahatma Gandhi Road, in the lane towards Adyar to go to Thiruvannmiyur, can take a U-turn at the intersection of Mahatma Gandhi Road and First Main Road in Shastri Nagar.

Motorists on Lattice Bridge Road, Adyar, going to Besant Nagar and Thiruvannmiyur, should turn left at Adyar Telephone Exchange junction, proceed on Shastri Nagar First Avenue, turn right into 11th Cross Street, and proceed through Eighth and Tenth Cross Streets to reach the intersection of Tenth Cross Street and Mahatma Gandhi Road.

At the junction, motorists can take the left to go towards Besant Nagar and the right towards Thiruvannmiyur. A new bus stop has been created, the Adyar Telephone Exchange bus stop for buses going towards ICF, Guindy, Mylapore, Island Grounds, Royapuram and Ennore. The bus stop is created on Shastri Nagar First Avenue, from which buses turn right at the Telephone Exchange junction to enter Lattice Bridge Road towards Adyar signal junction.

Indira Nagar 4th Avenue: a residential road losing its identity

ABINESH RAJA

Indira Nagar 4th Avenue has long been one of Adyar's prominent residential roads, serving hundreds of families, senior citizens, school-going children, and daily commuters. Today, however, this once-spacious avenue is gradually losing its identity due to the unchecked and unauthorised parking of private cabs and commercial vans.

The issue extends beyond 4th Avenue into the adjoining 26th Cross Street, where commercial vehicles are routinely parked for extended periods, effectively con-

verting public roads into private parking lots. As a result, the usable width of both roads has been drastically reduced, making movement difficult for motorists, cyclists, pedestrians and emergency vehicles alike.

The situation has become more concerning following the ongoing Chennai Metro Rail construction. With several Government buses now being diverted through 4th Avenue, these large vehicles are forced to navigate an already narrowed roadway. The combination of diverted public transport and illegally parked commercial vehicles has created daily traffic bot-

tlenecks and significantly increased the risk of accidents.

Safety is the biggest casualty. Rows of parked vans create blind spots that obstruct visibility for both motorists and pedestrians, particularly children crossing the road. Residents frequently find themselves unable to see approaching vehicles until the last moment, making even routine crossings hazardous.

Equally worrying is the impact on public safety after sunset. Long stretches occupied by unattended commercial vehicles reduce natural surveillance and create spaces that can encourage anti-social ac-

tivities. For a neighbourhood that is home to numerous families with young children, this is an unnecessary and preventable concern.

Public roads are meant to facilitate movement, not serve as permanent parking facilities for commercial fleets. While commercial operators undoubtedly require parking infrastructure, residential neighbourhoods should not bear the consequences of this burden.

The Greater Chennai Corporation, Chennai Traffic Police and the transport authorities concerned should jointly inspect Indira Nagar 4th Avenue and 26th

Cross Street. Regular enforcement against unauthorised commercial parking, installation of appropriate traffic signage and identification of designated parking spaces for commercial vehicles elsewhere would help restore both safety and accessibility.

As Metro construction continues to alter traffic patterns across the city, protecting residential roads from avoidable encroachments has become even more important. Timely intervention today will help preserve the safety, livability and character of one of Adyar's most vibrant neighbourhoods.

Earthen resolve

In Chennai, an enterprise focussed on making curd pots has completed its golden jubilee due to a man who would not give up. This enterprise is as small as it gets; it has two members on its rolls, he and his wife



▼ A whirlwind tour of the curd pot making unit at Royapettah; the people in the images are K. Manohar and M. Bhuvaneshwari.

PHOTOS: R. RAGU

drying the pots and firing them. He makes these pots with clay sourced from Red Hills. Every day, he manages to make 200-300 pots; after he has racked up around 2,000 pots, he initiates the firing process.

He maintains an inventory of 4000 pots at any point in time. Though not extremely keen on retailing, he does not shy away from it either. The pots are priced in the range of ₹8 to ₹10 each. He is content servicing that one bulk order, one that keeps him busy.

The address he operates from was apparently originally called Royapettah-Kosapet for its association with the making of clay pots and lamps. It was subsequently changed to Maavadi Vinayagar Koil Street. His workspace comes at a rent of ₹5000 per month; and the demand for firewood having gone up partly during the time there was a gripping fear of LPG shortage and not climbing down, his pot-making costs have gone up.

When he fires a batch of pots, he faces protest from neighbours on account of the smoke the process generates. To avoid friction with the neighbours, he restricts pot-firing to one day in a week, that too on a week day, so that when the process takes place, most residents are away, at their workplaces, schools and colleges. Manohar can be reached at 9790843188

Every day, he manages to make 200-300 pots; after he has racked up around 2,000 pots, he initiates the firing process

Every day, he manages to make 200-300 pots; after he has racked up around 2,000 pots, he initiates the firing process



R. RAGU

A resident of Maavadi Vinayagar Koil Street at Balaji Nagar in Royapettah, K. Manohar has been in the business of making small curd pots (*dahi handi*). Having seen 65 summers, Manohar has witnessed the vicissitudes of time, as has his business alongside him, which is obviously younger than him but not significantly. The business keeps “firing”, showing no signs of ageing; it is 50 years old.

There are challenges, but Manohar has soldiered on, watching his

business outlive even star hotels that once placed huge orders with him but have since slipped into oblivion.

As things stand, he supplies these pots to one star hotel in Chennai, the enterprise attracted to his creations for the novelty they bring to the table.

He functions with a two-member team, that is, if one counts him in. The only other team member is also his partner for life, M. Bhuvaneshwari his wife: talk about family-run business!

She chips in by helping him with preparations for processes such as

At the Oncology Kitchen at ICH, Egmore; and (below) the caretaker of a child undergoing treatment at ICH registering as part of the process to take food from the Oncology Kitchen to the child.



A worry taken off their plate

Oncology Kitchen at the Institute of Child Health and Hospital for Children in Egmore meets the huge nutritional needs of children undergoing cancer treatment. And the fact that the bill of fare comes free is a huge relief to their parents

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Malnutrition is cancer's wingman with a cruiser-ready shotgun. Cancer is formidable enough without this companion-in-arms by its side; and when the two team up, a two-front war is a necessity. At the government-run Institute of Child Health and Hospital for Children (ICH) in Egmore, oncologists and social workers are engaged in such a war, the former treating the children at the cancer ward and the latter, treating them to eats, as nourishing as they are tasty, at a unique kitchen.

It is called "Oncology Kitchen", clearly the rarest of rare lexical pairs. But this one enjoys easy familiarity with the tongues of its beneficiaries (at any given time around 50 children undergoing cancer treatment at ICH as well as a few children being treated for thalassemia) because from Monday to Saturday, between 10 a.m. and 11 a.m., the aroma of health food tas-

tily done wafts out of this kitchen and heads to the beds at the cancer ward. The caretaker of a child registers and takes the food to the ward. Children who are not weak might tag along with their caretakers, and following registration, have the food in the kitchen.

G.V. Williams, founder of the voluntary organisation Myrtle Social Welfare Network, which runs the Oncology Kitchen at ICH, notes this kitchen is hardly an add-on service, but one integral to cancer treatment which often causes severe weight loss and declining blood counts and ups nutritional demands significantly. Oncology Kitchen programme coordinator Tryphosa Mavis recalls the story of Devayani (name changed), a child diagnosed with blood cancer and who following treatment, was reduced to skin

COLLECTIVE KINDNESS
is a column about efforts by voluntary agencies and individual volunteers shoring up strikingly direct and noticeable initiatives by government agencies to serve the underprivileged sections of society



and bones. With proper nutrition and care from the Oncology Kitchen, she improved, gaining the necessary weight and showing adequately increased blood levels. Today, she visits the hospital only for monthly follow-ups, and has become an icon of hope for parents whose children are facing similar weight loss. Seeing Devayani, they know their child

too need not stay emaciated on account of cancer treatment.

The kitchen offers another balm to parents; in fact a cure, ridding them of the anxiety of having to provide their children up against cancer with nutritious food; it takes that worry off their plate.

Everything on the bill of fare at the Oncology Kitchen is free of cost. It was with this dual aim the Oncology Kitchen was launched at ICH on April 18, 2024, says Wil-

liams.

He rattles off the usual contents of the menu: rice porridge, health mix, cut fruits, milk, boiled eggs and sprouts. In addition, the kitchen offers customised meals. He elaborates that some children require to be on a specialised diet plan based on their condition and treatment and the preparation in the kitchen follows the food prescriptions written out by the oncologist. The kitchen serves 300 to 360 meals every week, with the total weekly cost ranging between ₹40,000 and ₹50,000. Among Myrtle's plans for the future is increasing the offering to three meals a day.

A close encounter

The inspiration to start Oncology Kitchen dates back to 2015, when Williams saw his friend lose his daughter to cancer; the girl was struck in the prime of her life, being just 20 years old at the time of death. Before her death, she wished that no child suffering from cancer should be left uncared for; even when facing the inevitable, her voice only reflected compassion, recalls Williams.

The kitchen is one of the outcomes of a memorandum of understanding Myrtle Social Welfare Network signed with ICH to support the children undergoing cancer treatment at the hospital and their parents in various ways. Besides seeking to keep these children in good health through the Oncology Kitchen, the voluntary organisation keeps them in good cheer through activities (for a sense of what they do at ICH), check out their Insta page @myrtle_social_welfare_network.

Notable ways in which secondary support shows up include: one, recognising that siblings are often neglected during a medical crisis, it provides educational support for them. It further conducts monthly parent support meetings where families share experiences, seek guidance and support one another through difficult times, Williams notes.

Among the assurances made to the hospital about the Oncology Kitchen is a commitment to maintaining hygiene and sanitation standards. Overseen by a manager and a supervisor, the kitchen comes with the assurance of FSSAI certification, says Williams.

Williams notes that when the idea of a kitchen of this stripe was up in the air, the hospital authorities and parents gave it a double thumbs up, displaying an unbiased mind. He adds that the government has definitely been benevolent with their constant support.

The NGO meets the expenditure with donations from individuals and organisations. People can also sponsor meals for the children undergoing treatment.

For details about the Oncology Kitchen, contact Myrtle Social Welfare Network at 9840096022.

Disabled activist honoured

In an event organised by Penakkal Peravai at Kotturpuram, K. Gopinath, Disabled Activist and District Chairperson for the Welfare of Differently Aabled Persons of Lions Clubs International, was honoured by Saidai S. Duraisamy, Founder of Manidhaneya Arakkattalai and former Mayor of Chennai Corporation, for his exemplary services and who has also dedicated his life to serving and rehabilitating the differently abled persons living all over Tamilnadu, says a press release. Founder of Penakkal Peravai Mohandass, Auditor Balasubramaniam, Writers Lena Tamilvanan, Noorullah, Philanthropists Muthukumarasamy, Namachivayam and several others participated in the event and graced the occasion.



Students go on a twisting spree



Chettinad Vidyashram observed International Yoga Day on the theme 'Sarvam Yoga Mayam' during the morning assembly on June 20. Sudama Vipra Das, vice president of ISKCON, graced the event.

S. Amudha Lakshmi, principal, emphasised the role of yoga in nurturing discipline, focus and physical fitness.

More than 100 students presented a

mass demonstration of various asanas and breathing exercises at the event conducted by the Yoga department. A few solo performers also demonstrated advanced asanas, highlighting their flexibility, focus, and confidence, said a release.

Vipra Das discussed the significance of yoga and encouraged students to embrace it as a lifelong practice to maintain a healthy, balanced life.

Best of songs from 1976

Satrangi's next presentation 'Best of 1956, 1966 & 1976' will be held on July 5 from 5:30 p.m. at TEACH Auditorium, Taramani.

This programme will feature memorable songs from movies like Bhai Bhai, Love In Tokyo, Do Badan, CID, Mehbooba, Chitchor, Mamta, Anupama, Aaye Din Bahaar Ke, Balika Badhu and Chhoti Si Baat.

The programme will be presented by Promod, Smriti and Ramya on pre recorded tracks.

Tickets for this event are priced at ₹500 and ₹300 and will be home delivered on calling 9884778073.

Humour club to meet today

Besant Nagar Humour Club is conducting its meet on July 5 at G3 Building, Third Floor, Bharathi Nagar Main Road (near Avvai Nagar) Thiruvananthapuram. Time: At 4 p.m. For details, call 9444755430.

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Academician honoured for 50 years of social service



J.C.D. Prabhakar, Speaker, Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, honouring J. Ramachandran at the felicitation ceremony.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

'Naesey' J. Ramachandran, founder of Naesey Charitable Trust and chancellor of AMET University,

was recently honoured for completing 50 years in social service.

Rajesh Ramachandran, president of AMET University, deli-

vered the welcome address and launched a documentary chronicling the academician's decades of social service, youth empowerment, employment generation,

and community development.

The programme saw eminent personalities from public life, academia, and politics who felicitated Ramachandran for his contributions.

Parveen Sultana, an orator, lauded Ramachandran's lifelong commitment to social service and his sustained efforts to empower youth, create livelihood opportunities, and establish institutions that have benefited society across diverse sectors.

J.C.D. Prabhakar, Speaker, Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, described Ramachandran as a humanitarian who dedicated himself to serving society even before achieving personal success.

Su. Thirunavukkarasar, former Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president, recalled his long association with Ramachandran and traced his inspiring journey from Valudavur village in Villupuram district to becoming an internationally recognized educationist.

"His initiatives have benefited nearly 2.5 lakh families, impacting close to one million people,"

Free textbooks for college students



Rajasthan Youth Association (RYA) Book Bank has started giving away application forms for its free textbooks scheme.

Students seeking books for B.Com, B.Com CS, BBM, BBA, B.Com CA, B.Com ISM, B.Sc Mathematics, BCA, B.Sc Computer Science can apply. Engineering students can opt from the second years of BE courses.

The free application form can also be collected from the RYA office at No.4, Atkinson Palace, Jothi Venkatachalam Road, behind Office of Commissioner of Police, Vepery; between 10.30 a.m. and 5.30 p.m. The form can also be downloaded online from www.ryabookbank.com.

Last date to apply is July 20.

For details, call 044-25610978 / Dinesh at 98402 03362

Essay contest

Nandini Voice for the Deprived, a not-for-profit organisation based in Chennai, is conducting an essay competition for students on the topic "Viksit Bharat 2047-

Prospects, Challenges and Strategies." The number of words should not exceed 2,000 words. It can be written either in English or in Tamil. Last date for submission is August 5.

The essay sent by email to

nsvenkatchennai@gmail.com or by post to the following address: Nandini Voice for the Deprived, H119, Flat No.2A, Ramaniyam Samudra, 33rd Cross Street, Besant Nagar, Chennai-600090. For details, call 044-43540719, 47662241

Workshop on making pickles



Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a culinary workshop on making pickles on July 9. Another workshop on making ice-creams from millets will be held on July 10. Both the sessions will be held at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048

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